

ONCE IN SHORT SUPPLY DURING THE PEAK OF THE PANDEMIC, VITAL PARAPHERNALIA USED IN THE PREVENTION AND TREATMENT OF COVID-19 REMAIN UNSOLD OR UNUSED, PUTTING MANUFACTURERS IN A SPOT

BY **NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA**

ILLUSTRATION BY **ANIRBAN GHOSH**

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AMBA SINGH, A DELHI-BASED medical equipment distributor, is eagerly waiting to free up space in his warehouse, now occupied by over a dozen oxygen concentrators that he bought in March 2021 when India was reeling under the second wave of the Covid-19 pandemic. The Chinese concentrators, which Singh had bought from domestic companies for ₹25,000 each and rented out for at least ₹10,000 a day to Covid-19 patients, haven't been used for over a

year. "Since there is no demand, I offered these to small local hospitals at throwaway prices, but they didn't want them," says Singh, who plans to donate them to charity since he has already recovered their cost.

Ventilators, oxygen concentrators, personal protective equipment (PPE) kits, oxygen cylinders and many other items that were considered life-savers during the initial days of the pandemic are now gathering dust at hospitals and manufacturing units. These commanded premium prices when Covid-19 was at its peak, but with the infection curve seeing a downward trend after December 2021, these products are no longer in demand.

CHALLENGING TIMES

"These are very challenging times for manufacturers of Covid-19-critical medical devices who had invested in plants and production lines for FFP2 (N95-equivalent) masks, surgical masks, oxygen therapy (ventilators, oxygen concentrators, high nasal flow oxygen equipment), syringes, etc., as demand has ebbed sharply and manufacturers are left with huge capacities of plant and machinery and unsold inventories," says Rajiv Nath, Forum Coordinator, Association of Indian Medical Device Industry (AiMeD).

Not just Indian companies, even multinational conglomerates like 3M are facing a slump in demand. For over 50 years, 3M's respirators such as the N95 have been used across industries, during natural disasters, and outbreaks such as the Covid-19 pandemic. "We approximately

doubled global capacity of manufacturing respirators to support the frontline workers during the pandemic," says Ashutosh Shirodkar, Executive Director and Country Business Group Leader-Safety & Industrial Business Group, 3M India, adding that with the pandemic waning, there has been "reduced demand for respirators from the healthcare sector".

According to AiMeD, nearly one-third of the country's medical device manufacturing capacity is lying unused. Vivek Tiwari, Founder & CEO of Medikabazaar, a B2B store for hospital supplies, says that during the second wave, manufacturers ramped up production of ventilators, PPE kits and masks to meet demand. "As a result, hospitals and supply-chain partners are still carrying a large number of unused equipment and most of this is lying in the top 20 cities of the country," he says, adding that before the pandemic, India used to manufacture only 6 million PPE kits per annum, which was ramped up to over 230 million.

"Similarly, capacity for ventilators and surgical masks had gone up by 10 times during the peak of Covid-19," he says. While there has been a sharp decline in demand with the pandemic receding, the recurring demand for PPE kits, masks, gloves and sanitisers is still higher than pre-Covid-19 levels due to increased awareness and endemic protocols. "But medical equipment and devices like pulse oximeters, thermometers, oxygen concentrators and ventilators have seen a decline in demand."

Medikabazaar's operating revenue grew